

Angkor Wat

The city of Angkor, built by the Hindu Khmer kings of northwest Cambodia between the 9th and 15th centuries, contains the monumental complex of Angkor Wat – the world's largest religious monument – constructed by King Suryavarman (r.1113–45) as a temple to the god Vishnu and as a royal mausoleum. It is laid out to symbolize the universe: the central structure represents the holy Mount Meru, home to the Hindu gods; the five surrounding towers are the mountain peaks that were thought to mark the edge of the cosmos; and the broad moat represents the oceans believed to lie beyond.

The main temple building has three tiered terraces that represent earth, water and wind. The many bas-reliefs that adorn the buildings are detailed representations of Hindu mythology. It is an act of veneration to circumambulate a Hindu temple, and the ambulatory of Angkor Wat amounts to 19 kilometres (12 miles). The complex was later copied across the Khmer Empire, but no other Hindu temple attained such scale and precision.

